

Rediscovering My Calling in My Marriage With YOU

A Marriage Enrichment Exercise for Married Couples
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*The great secret of a happy choice may be given in a single sentence: it consists in uniting the **taste** and the **judgment** equally in the selection. Let the former be the active power, going forward in the choice; and let the latter be the satisfying power, endorsing or else vetoing, as the case may be. If both are satisfied, there is not much danger of forming a connection that will be regretted hereafter.*

B.M. Palmer, Letter to R.H. Reid, *The Life and Letters of Benjamin Morgan Palmer*,

- A. Plan a special “get-away” evening or weekend to be alone with your spouse—preferably a place and time that is without any distractions of children or work.
- B. PRIOR TO the designated evening or weekend, take however much time is required to complete the following questions: (Each partner will need to have their own copy of this handout, available on CPC Website)
 1. These are the qualities about you that cause me to respect you:
✓
✓
✓
✓
✓
 2. These are the qualities about you that cause me to be attracted to you:
✓
✓
✓
✓
✓
 3. These are some things about you that often make me laugh? (E.g. no sarcasm or “course jesting” here—something about your spouse that is “funny,” NOT negative!)
 4. One of the more fun moments/experiences that I remember having with you is as follows: (What do you think were the reasons/conditions that made this so fun for you?)

5. Share with your spouse your greatest "fear" in life at this point in time? (*This would be a good time to pray for each other*)

6. I believe we are vocationally compatible in the following ways:
 - a. Family Goals/Values

 - b. Career Goals/Values

 - c. Church Goals/Values

7. I believe we are vocationally challenged in the following ways and would be willing, with you, to find appropriate compromises as long as it doesn't compromise my calling and relationship with God. (see post-enrichments activities)
 - a. Family Goals/Values

 - b. Career Goals/Values

 - c. Church Goals/Values

8. I want to confess the following sins/wrongs that I have either inadvertently or consciously done against you in our marriage. (Something you have done/not done that you know you ought to have done/not done. We all have them!).
James 5:16 Therefore confess our sins to one another, and pray for one another, so that you may be healed. The prayer of the righteous is powerful and effective.

9. Concerning the sin of X (as per #8) I want you to know that I forgive you and really desire for you to know that I accept you even as I know that I am forgiven by Christ for sins much worse than these as committed against God by me!
Col.3:13 Bear with one another and, if anyone has a complaint against another, forgive each other; just as the Lord has forgiven you, so you also must forgive.

10. Friendship is an important aspect of becoming "one flesh." IN order to foster this in one another, what would be your perfect "date" with your spouse? Be detailed and specific. (Be sure that you are realistic as per the your financial/time/personal means) See then post-enrichment activities.
11. Sexual intimacy is enjoined upon marriages for the mutual benefit and enjoyment of both husband and wife. It is the "sacred ritual" of "becoming one flesh" that both symbolized and effects the mysterious body/soul oneness that is to be more and more experienced between a man and a women in marriage (Gen.2:24) as even typologically related to the mystery of oneness that the object of redemptive history as between Christ and the church. It is no less vital to the mystery of marriage as the sacraments are to the mystery Christ and His church. The Bible therefore celebrates sexual intimacy in marriage, even as it exhorts marriage partners not to "deprive one another..." (1Cor.7:5). Sexual intimacy ought to be enjoyed by both partners, even as it is right and good to fantasize for one another as poetically illustrated by the *Song of Solomon* in the Bible. Sexual intimacy in marriage is as much about our willingness to be vulnerable with our spouse as an act of entrusting ourself to him/her in marriage. It is not an exercise in self-gratification to desire one another sexually, but rather an exercise of mutual gratification in the spirit of 1Cor.7:3-4.

1Cor. 7:3

The husband should give to his wife her conjugal rights, and likewise the wife to her husband. 4 For the wife does not have authority over her own body, but the husband does; likewise the husband does not have authority over his own body, but the wife does. 5 Do not deprive one another except perhaps by agreement for a set time, to devote yourselves to prayer, and then come together again, so that Satan may not tempt you...

With this being said, What would be your romantic/sexual fantasy with your spouse? Be specific and detailed, as to include the before and after even. See post-enrichment activities.

12. Finally, what in your words describes a "calling" to be married to your specific spouse in order to reflect God's will for your marriage? E.g. "What is God's purpose for me to be married to you?" (As a *calling*, this will mean thinking about how you see yourself serving/ministering to your spouse as a service to God)

- C. Now, during your designated marriage enrichment evening or weekend, share with one another your answers! This is a time to be honest, vulnerable and accepting! You will want to do what is in your power to help your spouse feel no need for defensiveness or anxiousness about sharing with you. You will want to do what is in your power to help your spouse feel loved, accepted and "safe" throughout discussions!

Post-Enrichment Activities and Resources:

1. AS per the vocational issues in your marriage, determine a time when you can have a "planning day," even as I would strongly advise that you have an annual "family planning" event as well. The elements of a good plan include:
 - a. A Description of your "vision" for your family
 - i. Purpose
 - ii. What it would look like in a perfect world
 - b. Set Goals:
 - i. Family General/Weekly/Monthly/Annual Goals
 - ii. Specific Parenting Goals (if applicable)
 - iii. Specific Financial Goals as per the above plans
 - iv. Specific Vocation Goals as specifically related to family planning
 - v. Long-term goals and plans relative to the "next phase of life..."
 - c. Work out a strategy for each goal
 - d. Work out plan with both determination and flexibility as per the providence of God... e.g. be gracious when it is discovered that your goals were too ambitious. They usually are!!!
2. Having now heard one another's ideal "date" each determine to make this happen for your spouse in a reasonably short period of time.
3. Having now heard one another's romantic/sexual fantasy, determine to give this to your spouse within a reasonably short period of time...
4. If for some reason you are unable to complete the above exercise due to relationship difficulties, YOU NEED HELP! Do not wait, seek pastoral counseling, remembering that pastoral care is God's instrument to mediate his healing presence in your life, even as mediated through his church!
5. Resources:

Poetry for a Romantic Evening:

 - ✓ Song of Solomon
 - ✓ *Epithalamion* by Edmund Spenser (copies available at church)
 - ✓ other?

Recommended Books/Readings on Marriage:

 - ✓ *Sermon, "The Transcendent Calling of Marriage"* (on church website in print, available on CD from CPC Recording Ministry)

- ✓ *The Calling of Marriage*, Preston Graham (one church website)
- ✓ *The Marriage Builder* Lawrence Crabb
- ✓ *Intimate Allies*, Dan Allender and Tremper Longman
- ✓ *Master Your Money*, Ron Blue